PART II

Time

Music moves through time. Underneath it runs a steady **pulse**; the pulse is grouped into **bars**; and every note and rest takes a measured share of it. This part goes from that big picture down to the length of a single note.

1 **Pulse** — the steady beat underneath

›

2 **Bar** — beats in groups of 2, 3 or 4

›

3 **Time signature** — how many beats, and which note is one beat

›

4 **Note values** — how long each sound lasts

›

5 **Rhythm** — the pattern of long and short

IN THIS PART

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PART II · TIME · 1

Pulse, tempo and the bar

Under almost every piece runs a **pulse**: a steady beat, like a heartbeat or a clock. Its speed is the **tempo**. Beats are grouped into **bars**, and the first beat of every bar is the strongest.

Tempo

Tempo is measured in beats per minute. A **metronome mark** at the top of the music shows it: ♩ **= 60** means 60 crotchet beats a minute, one beat a second. ♩ **= 120** is twice as fast. Tempo words such as *Andante* and *Allegro* are on page 70.

Strong and weak beats

BEATS	PATTERN	FEELS LIKE
2	**Strong** weak	a march
3	**Strong** weak weak	a waltz
4	**Strong** weak **medium** weak	most songs

Bars and bar lines

SIGN	NAME	MEANING
	bar line	divides the music into bars
	double bar line	marks the end of a section, or a change of key, time signature or tempo
	final bar line	marks the end of the piece
	repeat signs	play the passage between them again; if there is no start sign, go back to the beginning

Counting



Three bars of 3/4. Every beat is counted, even inside a long note: the coral number is where you play, the grey numbers are the beats you hold.

Count aloud at one speed, a little louder on beat 1. With a metronome, start slower than you think and speed up only when the passage is steady.

WATCH OUT

- × Speeding up in the easy bars and slowing down in the hard ones: choose a tempo you can keep in the hardest bar.
- × Counting the notes instead of the beats.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 39 · Tempo words p. 70

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Pulse · Online: Metronome

PART II · TIME · 2

Notes and rests

A note's shape shows how long it lasts: each plain note lasts **half as long** as the one above it. Every note has a **rest** of the same length, a silence counted just as carefully as a sound.

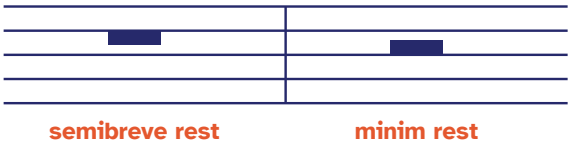
NOTE	REST	NAME	IN THE USA	BEATS*	FIRST MET
		breve	double whole note	**8**	Level 4
		dotted semibreve	dotted whole note	**6**	*Extra*
		semibreve	whole note	**4**	Level 0
		**dotted minim**	dotted half note	**3**	Level 0
		**minim**	half note	**2**	Level 0
		**dotted crotchet**	dotted quarter note	**1½**	Level ½
		**crotchet**	quarter note	**1**	Level 0
		**dotted quaver**	dotted eighth note	**¾**	Level 3
		**quaver**	eighth note	**½**	Level 0
		**semiquaver**	sixteenth note	**¼**	Level 2
		**demisemiquaver**	32nd note	**⅛**	*Extra*
		**hemidemisemiquaver**	64th note	**1/16**	*Extra*

* With the crotchet as one beat, as in 2/4, 3/4 and 4/4. *Extra*: beyond Level 8.

Parts of a note

The **head** sits on a line or in a space. A **stem** goes up on the right of the head or down on the left. **Flags** on the stem halve the value each time; groups of quavers are joined by **beams** instead of flags.

Which rest is which?



The semibreve rest **hangs** below the fourth line; the minim rest **sits** on the middle line.

PART II · TIME · 2

How long is a note?

Each row lasts exactly as long as the row above it: the same stretch of time, cut in half again and again.



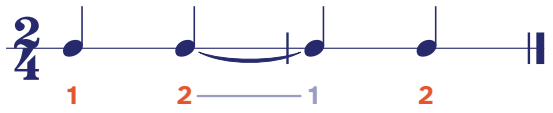
The dot

A dot adds **half the note's value**: a dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 = 3 beats; a dotted crotchet 1 + ½ = 1½. A **double dot** adds half, then a quarter: a double-dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 + ½ = 3½.



The tie

A curve joining two notes **of the same pitch** makes one longer sound: play the first, hold through the second. Ties can cross a bar line, where a dot cannot.



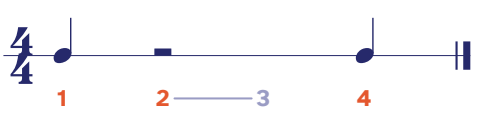
TIE OR SLUR?

The same curve over notes of **different** pitches is a **slur**: play them smoothly joined (legato). Same pitch: a tie. Different pitches: a slur.

Rests in a bar



✓ The silence on beats 3–4 is one minim rest; a whole silent bar takes a semibreve rest, in any time signature.



× In 4/4, a minim rest on beats 2–3 hides the middle of the bar: write two crotchet rests.

SEE ALSO

Time signatures p. 39 · Rhythm p. 41

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Note values · Online: Library › Notes and rests

PART II · TIME · 3

Time signatures

Two numbers at the start of the music. The **top number** says how many counts are in each bar; the **bottom number** says which note gets one count.

The bottom number

BOTTOM	NOTE	ONE COUNT IS A	FIRST MET
2		minim	Level 3
4		crotchet	Level 0
8		quaver	Level 1
16		semiquaver	*Extra*

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

Quick test: a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

Simple time: each beat divides in two

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
2/4	2 crotchets	Level 0
3/4	3 crotchets	Level 0
4/4 	4 crotchets (the C sign: common time)	Level 0
2/2 	2 minims (the cut C: cut common time)	Level 3
3/2	3 minims	Level 3
4/2	4 minims	*Extra*
3/8	3 quavers	Level 3

Changing time signature

A new time signature can appear in the middle of a piece, right after a bar line; it holds until the next one. A time signature is written only once, not on every line.

WATCH OUT

- × Reading 6/8 as six beats: at most speeds it moves in two.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: both hold six quavers, grouped differently (page 40).

SEE ALSO

Pulse and the bar p. 36 · Compound time p. 40

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Time signatures · Online: Library › Time signatures

PART II · TIME · 3

Compound and irregular time

Compound time has dotted beats that divide into three; irregular time has five or seven counts, grouped unevenly. (9/4, 12/4 and the /16 signatures exist but are rare.)

Compound time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
6/8	2 dotted crotchets	Level 1
9/8	3 dotted crotchets	Level 3
12/8	4 dotted crotchets	Level 3
6/4	2 dotted minims	Level 4

Counting 6/8



Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

3/4 or 6/8?



3/4: six quavers in three twos



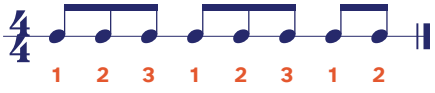
6/8: six quavers in two threes

Irregular time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
5/4	5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	Level 0
7/4	7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4	*Extra*
5/8	5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	*Extra*
7/8	7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2	*Extra*

UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.



PART II · TIME · 4

Rhythm: groups and upbeats

Rhythm is the pattern of long and short sounds over the pulse. The pulse stays steady; the rhythm moves around it. The way notes are grouped on the page shows where the beats are.

Grouping with beams

Beams join the notes of **one beat**, so the beats stay visible. In 4/4 a beam may cover beats 1–2 or 3–4, but never cross the middle of the bar. In compound time, quavers are beamed in threes.



✓ The middle of the bar can be seen.



× A beam across beats 2–3 hides it.

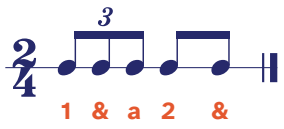
The upbeat (anacrusis)

A piece can begin **before** the first full bar, with one or more notes called an upbeat or anacrusis. The last bar is then short by the same amount, so the two together make one full bar. Count the missing beats in silence before you start.



Count “1 2” silently, then play on 3.

Triplets and duplets



Triplet: three notes in the time of two.

Level 2. Three exactly equal notes.



Duplet: two notes in the time of three, in compound time.

Level 2.

Counting smaller values



Crotchet, two quavers, four semiquavers and a triplet (“1 & a”): one beat each.

PART II · TIME · 4

Rhythm: off the beat

Once the pulse is secure, rhythm can pull against it. Every one of these effects needs a steady beat underneath.

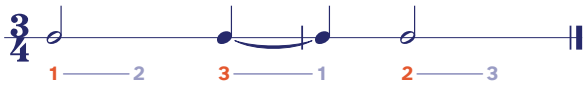
Syncopation



The crotchet starts on “&” and is held through beat 2.

Level 4. Feel beat 2 even though nothing is played on it.

Hemiola



Two bars of 3/4 felt as three minims.

Level 4. Common at cadences in Baroque dances.

Swing Level ½

Common from the first pieces: jazz, blues and many easy modern pieces are marked *swing*. Pairs of quavers are written evenly but played **long–short**, like the first and last notes of a triplet.

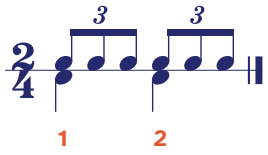


Written



Played

Polyrhythm Level 7



Three against two: a triplet above, two crotchets below, starting together.

Rubato Extra

Time is stretched and then given back, for expression: the music leans into a phrase and catches up after it. The pulse always returns. Marked *rubato*, or simply part of the style in much Romantic music.

WATCH OUT

- × Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- × Playing a triplet unevenly: three equal notes, not two quick and one long.
- × Letting syncopation drag the pulse: tap the beat with your foot.

SEE ALSO
Notes and rests p. 37 · Words for how to play p. 70

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock